

Zeke Zalinski

Director of UX / Experience Strategy & Design Systems

Summary

Design executive with 25+ years spanning fine art, agency creative direction, e-commerce, and brand. For the last decade, building and restructuring UX organizations inside VC-backed SaaS environments, including the unification of fragmented product experiences across acquired portfolios. Recruited directly by C-suite leadership at both of my last two roles to establish process and standards from the ground up and deliver unified experiences across multi-product portfolios. Equally fluent in craft and strategy, with the range to operate at both the pixel and the executive level.

Capabilities

- UX org buildout, team mentorship & talent development
- Cross-functional leadership: thought leadership, product, customer success, design, back-end, front-end dev
- C-suite partnership and executive design strategy
- Design systems architecture: scalable guardrails for engineering autonomy
- AI-assisted design workflow integration (Figma Make, Lovable, Claude)
- UX Direction: wireframes, prototypes & specs
- Continuous discovery and research integration
- Post-acquisition UX unification and portfolio convergence

Work Experience

VelocityEHS / Director of User Experience & Design / June 2021 – May 2026

Promoted to Director in Sep 2022 after 15 months leading the integration of a newly acquired company's software onto the VelocityEHS design system. Recruited directly by the CTO, a relationship built over five years at Maestro Health, to assess and restructure a UX department supporting a mixed portfolio of 20+ organically built and acquired EHS and ESG SaaS products.

- Grew the Accelerate Design System from one product's component library into the standard across 20+ products, scaling it with Front End across 6 Scrum teams.
- Caught a gap between the navigation experience leadership was promising and what the product actually delivered, then led the fix: Accelerate Navigation, now the company-wide standard.
- Designed the brand and interaction model for Velo, an embedded AI assistant, making machine-learning features feel simple and trustworthy to everyday users.
- Brought AI tools like Figma Make and Lovable into the department's own workflow, cutting the time from idea to stakeholder buy-in.
- Mentored the team through harder systems problems, then trimmed it from 8 to 5, keeping the people ready to grow into more.
- Built an in-house WCAG/VPAT accessibility practice, led by a Senior Designer instead of an outside vendor, to meet enterprise and education-sector requirements.
- Brought UX directly into client conversations for the first time, turning scattered feedback into a real, repeatable practice.

Career Pause / Full-time Parent / February 2020 – June 2021

Stepped back from professional work to manage family full-time during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Maestro Health / Director of Experience Design / February 2015 – February 2020

Recruited by referral from a former colleague to join a 30-person healthcare startup as its first and only UX voice. Tasked with ownership of the full experience, from discovery through delivery.

- Served as the sole UX leader across 12 healthcare applications for three years, owning the full experience in a regulated, data-heavy environment.
- Designed custom applications from the ground up that replaced paper-based HR workflows, solving problems no one had digitized before.
- Built the department's UX process from scratch, scaling it as the company grew from a 30-person startup to a full insurance platform.
- Made a deliberate first hire in year three: a research and documentation specialist, brought on exactly when the product's complexity demanded it.

Siteworx / Creative Director, Chicago / September 2012 – September 2013

One of four founding directors of Siteworx's first remote office, the only location to launch with leadership across all four pillars: sales, development, engagement, and design.

- Led the creative department through the full client lifecycle: discovery and stakeholder interviews, concept, production, and development handoff.
- Concepted and presented directly for clients like Grant Thornton and American College of Surgeons, with the ACS design direction selected and winning the contract.
- Operated as a peer director alongside sales, development, and engagement leads: a full business partner in strategy, pitches, SOW approvals, and resource planning.

Earlier Career / Art Direction, Design & Creative Leadership / 2001 – 2012

- **Lyons Consulting Group**, Associate Creative Director (2011 – 2012): led the agency's rebrand end-to-end and served as primary client-facing creative lead.
- **Gorilla**, Senior Design Lead (2010 – 2011): e-commerce and IA lead during the agency's 2010 Magento Partner of the Year year; IMCA Award for Axient.net.
- **Envisionit Media**, Art Director (2006 – 2010): built the agency's print production infrastructure, then extended it to cover web as the shop shifted from print-first to digital.
- **Italia Partners & Z Design** (contract), Senior Designer / Art Director (2001 – 2006): national campaign work for CompUSA, Chicago Tribune, Foote Cone & Belding, and Euro RSCG Tatham.

Education

Illinois State University

Bachelor of Fine Arts, Graphic Design